



DECCAN TRAPS

Some scientists have suggested that massive volcanic eruptions in what is now central India may also have contributed to the extinction event. These volcanoes had been continuously erupting for just under a million years, and the eruptions may have intensified as a result of the asteroid impact. The lava flow from the eruptions formed the layers of rock pictured here, which are known as the Deccan Traps.

A huge number of gases were released into the atmosphere when the asteroid hit Earth's crust.

Asteroid impact

When the asteroid crashed into Earth, it left its mark in the planet's rocks. A thin layer of sediment lies between the Late Cretaceous rocks and the more recent rocks from the Paleogene Period. This band of rock is called the Cretaceous–Paleogene (K–Pg) boundary. It is rich in iridium, an element that is rare on Earth but common in asteroids.

This iridium may have been deposited as a cloud of dust after the asteroid hit Earth. Fossils of all nonbird dinosaurs are found in rocks below this thin boundary layer.